Lesson 40: Argument: A Model Essay and the Rhetorical Appeals

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 5: Argument and Academic Style

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 5.1 Introduction; 5.2 Sample Student Research Essay - Fast Fashion; 5.3 Distinguishing Rhetorical Appeals.

In this lesson

You start the unit on argument: the methods writers use to get readers to believe an idea or take an action. You read a student research essay that argues for regulating the "fast fashion" industry, and you learn Aristotle's three rhetorical appeals: pathos, ethos and logos. Analyzing arguments helps you understand different perspectives in every academic discipline, and it is the first step toward writing your own argument.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain what rhetoric is and name the three rhetorical appeals.
- Identify pathos, ethos and logos in a text and say which clues show them.
- Describe how an argumentative research essay is built: thesis, support, concession, counterargument and conclusion.
- Write the introduction to an argument that uses all three appeals.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
argument (argumentation)	the methods writers use to get readers to believe an idea or take an action	an essay arguing for stronger regulations
persuade	get other people to agree with you	Writers persuade their audience.
rhetoric	the study of the art of persuasion and how we use it in speaking and writing	Aristotle wrote about rhetoric.
rhe·TOR·i·cal appeal	one of three ways of persuading an audience	pathos, ethos, logos
PA·thos	an appeal to feelings: emotion, senses and story	the 16-year-old in a clothing store
E·thos	an appeal to credibility (trust): fairness, thoughtfulness, expert sources	Dr. Luz Claudio … is a neuroscientist
LO·gos	an appeal to logic: reasons with evidence	facts about polyester and pollution

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
rhetorical triangle	the three appeals shown as one triangle, because they work together	pathos, ethos and logos at the three corners
fast fashion	clothing produced quickly and cheaply, following the latest trends, but not made to last	H&M, Zara, Uniqlo
living wage	pay high enough for workers to afford their basic needs	$336 a month in Bangladesh
concession	admitting that another view has some truth	It is true that the industry has made some progress ...
counterargument	an answer to the other side's argument	This argument is compelling from a distance, but ...

Rules and explanations

Why argument matters

- Analyzing arguments helps you understand different perspectives on a problem; writing arguments helps you convince readers and inspire them to act.
- It helps in every academic discipline, in your career and in civic life. It is your entry into "The Great Conversation": the ongoing discussion of what ideas are true and how we know this.
- In this unit you will identify, evaluate and write the three appeals; analyze deductive logic; refute logical fallacies; write concessions and counterarguments; and use hedging language.

The theme: fast fashion

"Fast fashion" is clothing produced quickly and cheaply, following the latest design trends, to meet consumer demand, but not made to last. It raises controversial ethical issues: it causes environmental damage (pollution and wasted resources) and unfair labor practices. However, people need affordable clothing, and laws and boycotts against the industry sometimes have unintended negative consequences.

Rhetoric and the three appeals

Rhetoric is the study of the art of persuasion and of how we apply it to effective speaking and writing. When you write an argument, you help your readers make a decision: to agree with you, to understand and accept your main idea, and perhaps to act on it. The Greek philosopher Aristotle (called "The First Teacher" by medieval Muslim scholars) described three **rhetorical appeals**:

Appeal	It is about	The writer ...	Clues
pathos	feelings	connects to readers' values through emotion, senses and story	a story about a person, sensory details, emotional words

Appeal	It is about	The writer ...	Clues
ethos	credibility	builds trust by presenting the argument fairly and thoughtfully, and by using information from expert sources	credentials, fair treatment of other views
logos	logic	sets up a solid structure of reasons with evidence	facts, statistics, reasons, "therefore"

- An effective argumentative essay uses all three; they work together (the "rhetorical triangle").
- There is always some overlap, so look for the strongest clue.

The model essay: "Deadly Fashion"

In "Deadly Fashion", two students, Maroua Abdelghani and Ruri Tamimoto, argue that fast fashion harms workers and the environment and needs government regulation. As you read, notice the personal story at the start, the thesis that names the other side, the cited evidence in each body paragraph, a paragraph that admits some progress (a concession), a paragraph that answers the opposing view (a counterargument), and a call to action at the end. It is a student essay, so a few small errors remain: for example, "In fact, According" in paragraph 1 has a wrong capital letter, and two sources (Drew in paragraph 2, Ozdamar-Ertekin in paragraph 6) are missing from the Works Cited list.

> **Psychology note:** The essay uses MLA citations, such as (274) after a sentence that names Joy. Psychology uses APA style, where the year is always added: (Joy et al., 2012, p. 274).

Practice

Exercise 1. Reading the model essay. Read "Deadly Fashion" in your lesson material (5.2).

1. How does the essay begin? Which appeal does this opening use most?
2. What is the thesis statement, and where is it? Which part of it mentions the other side?
3. What is the main point of each body paragraph (paragraphs 2 to 6)?
4. In paragraph 2, how do the writers show that women garment workers are "paid less than a third of a necessary living wage"? Which appeal is this?
5. Find two places where the writers build ethos for a source by giving a credential.
6. Find the quotation in paragraph 3 that appeals most strongly to pathos.
7. In paragraph 6, what is the opposing argument, and how do the writers answer it?
8. What do the writers ask consumers and governments to do in the conclusion?

Exercise 2. Identifying rhetorical appeals. Imagine you are writing a paper to convince your readers that cheaply produced, low-quality clothing is a bad choice for consumers and that the clothing industry should be more regulated by governments. Read items 1 to 6 in your lesson material (5.3, "Identifying rhetorical appeals"). Which ones are examples of pathos, ethos or logos? Look for clues: is

the writer using emotion, senses, story? Are they working to appear fair, and to explain why we should trust a source? Are they presenting facts to support a claim? Say which clue helped you.

1. "On March 25, 1911, a fire broke out in the Triangle Shirtwaist Company factory ..."
2. "Dr. Luz Claudio, the author of the study, is a neuroscientist, medical researcher, and professor of environmental medicine and public health at Mount Sinai University."
3. "We can all agree that societies thrive when workers are paid enough to meet their basic needs. However, the workers in textile factories that supply fast fashion brands are paid as little as 40 cents an hour. Therefore, the practices of this industry are harming the societies where the factories are located."
4. "Besides labor exploitation, another reason fast fashion is so destructive is that it leaves a pollution footprint ..."
5. "A 16-year-old walks into a brightly-lit store in a shopping plaza in Sacramento ..."
6. "It's true that there has been some incremental progress toward improving working conditions ..."

Speak with your tutor

- "Check my answers to Exercise 1, questions 1, 3 and 7. Are my explanations clear and accurate?"
- "Here is an advertisement, public service announcement or news article I found: [paste or describe]. These are the examples of pathos, ethos and logos I found. Do you agree? Did I miss any?"
- "Take the side of Benjamin Powell: sweatshops help poor countries develop. Argue with me about regulating fast fashion. After five turns, tell me which of my points used pathos, ethos or logos, and which was strongest."
- "Here is the introduction I wrote: [paste]. Which appeals do I use? How can I add or improve the weakest one?"

Read aloud

Pause briefly at each | mark.

1. Rhetoric is the study of the art of persuasion | and of how we apply that art to effective speaking and writing.
2. PA·thos is about feelings, | E·thos is about credibility, | and LO·gos is about logic.
3. Although some defend the fast fashion industry's aesthetic and economic contributions, | it has devastating impacts on labor rights and the environment, | and needs serious regulations by all nations to stop the damage.
4. A bad sewing job is an inconvenience for me, | but unethical practices are the real issue.
5. Major changes are needed in the system, | and for that we need stronger government regulations | to ensure real change.

Writing task

Begin an argument. Choose a controversial question:

- the book's topic: Should governments regulate the fast fashion industry?
- a psychology topic: Should high schools start later so that teenagers get enough sleep? Should schools teach students skills for coping with stress?
- your research topic from Lessons 32 to 39, turned into a question that people disagree about.

Write the introduction to an argument essay (180-250 words):

- a hook that uses pathos: a short story or a vivid example, as "Deadly Fashion" does;
- one or two sentences of background with a fact from a source, introduced with a credential and cited (ethos and logos); for a psychology topic, look in the OpenStax "Psychology 2e" textbook, Google Scholar or PubMed Central;
- a thesis statement at the end that takes a clear position and names the other side ("Although some …, …").

Below your paragraph, write one example of each appeal you used, labeled "pathos", "ethos" and "logos".

Self-editing checklist:

- My hook tells a story or gives a vivid example, and it is sincere, not exaggerated.
- My background fact comes from a source, has a credential and an in-text citation.
- My thesis is the last sentence, takes a clear position and names the other side.
- I can point to pathos, ethos and logos in my paragraph.
- My reporting verbs fit the type of evidence.
- My citation follows MLA (or APA for a psychology course), and I have a Works Cited entry for the source.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- "Ethos, Pathos & Logos", a short video by the Texas A&M University Writing Center (used in 5.3): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=aUpiy67_nt4

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. With a personal story: the writer's $9.99 t-shirt that is no longer wearable after two washes, and later the questions about the person who sewed it. (example answer) It appeals mostly to pathos (a story and an everyday experience readers share); it also makes the writer seem honest and thoughtful, which builds ethos.
2. "Although some defend the fast fashion industry's aesthetic and economic contributions, it has devastating impacts on labor rights and the environment, and needs serious regulations by all nations to stop the damage." It is the last sentence of paragraph 1. The other side: "Although some defend the fast fashion industry's aesthetic and economic contributions".
3. Paragraph 2: factory workers are paid too little, and their requests for living wages are ignored. Paragraph 3: workers also suffer terrible daily working conditions. Paragraph 4 (concession): the industry has made some progress in labor rights since the Rana Plaza disaster, but low pay and inhumane daily conditions remain. Paragraph 5: producing cheap clothing causes significant pollution (pesticides on cotton, water pollution, carbon emissions). Paragraph 6 (counterargument): some argue that the industry gives work to people with few better choices; the writers reject this argument.
4. Workers are paid about $96 per month, but the government estimates $336 as the minimum for basic needs; a third of $336 is $112, so $96 is less than a third. This is logos (facts and a calculation that lead to a conclusion).
5. Any two credentials, for example: "anthropologist and marketing professor Annamma Joy"; "Deborah Drew, an associate at the World Resource Institute's Center for Sustainable Business"; "Ken Loo, secretary-general of the Garment Manufacturers Association of Cambodia"; "Sadika Akhter, an anthropologist and doctor of Environmental Public Health"; "Research scientist Luz Claudio"; "investigative reporter Adam Matthews"; "Benjamin Powell, the director of the Free Market Institute".
6. The machine operator's words: "We sew shirts with our tears and injure our fingers due to needle punctures. If you work at the garment factory it will give you some money but it will take your health. . . ."
7. The opposing argument: the fashion industry provides work to people with few better choices in developing countries; Benjamin Powell argues that this model is "part of the process that raises living standards and leads to better working conditions and development over time". The writers answer that the argument is "compelling from a distance" and may be true to some degree historically, but it disregards the humanity of current garment workers, who work long hours in brutal conditions while owners make huge profits. They call it "a cynical justification for greed".
8. Consumers should buy second-hand clothes, look for companies making apparel in the U.S., and be willing to pay more for higher-quality clothing that lasts. But the main change must come from stronger government regulations.

Exercise 2 (book)

1. pathos · 2. ethos · 3. logos · 4. logos · 5. pathos · 6. ethos

Clues: 1, a dramatic story with sensory details (heat, smoke, the ledge, the fall); 2, an expert's credentials; 3, a general principle, a fact and "Therefore" (reasoning); 4, facts about polyester, production and emissions, from a cited source; 5, a story about a person, with sensory details and feelings ("thrilled", "nightmares"); 6, the writer is fair (admits "some incremental progress") and quotes a credible source with her credentials (former child worker, union organizer, leader of the Bangladesh Center for Worker Solidarity).

My notes